

Touch-n-Feel Vs. Tap-n-Click



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“Born in an offline buying world, I’ve taken to online shopping much like a fish to water. Having said that, I still do most of my shopping offline, even when it comes to buying tech products.”

Technology is great at simplifying our lives. It takes something as complicated and cumbersome as offline shopping and makes it jaw-droppingly convenient and addictive via online shopping. Every negative emotion that you associate with offline shopping – anxiety, patience (waiting in line), fear (of crowds), etc. – fades away with the click of a button on your smartphone or PC; it’s so much more convenient. Why would anyone step out in the sun, brave traffic and go out of their way to buy something from a physical store when the same thing can be bought online with zero tension?

I would, and I’ll tell you why. For all its demerits, the good ol’ way of buying products – tech or otherwise – still remains popular in our country, despite the seemingly exponential growth in e-commerce over the past couple of years. Brick-and-mortar stores will let you do certain things in areas where online stores are found wanting despite all their glittering positives.

Believe me, I’m not a luddite. Despite being born in an offline buying era, I’ve taken to online shopping like a fish to water. Having said that, I still do most of my shopping offline, even tech. Especially tech. I want to be absolutely sure of the product I’m purchasing. I want to touch and feel it, ensure it meets my exacting standards and tick off all my doubts and apprehensions before agreeing to put my money where my mouth is. Especially for products that haven’t passed through our test centre.

I’ll be the first to admit that I’m enormously lazy when it comes to going out to shop, and certainly don’t indulge in it every other weekend either (who will watch all of those Premier League games?) But, whenever I head out to shop (after doing my research on what to buy, rates, etc), there’s one aspect of buying offline that I truly enjoy. Buying things that I didn’t plan on buying. Like going to Lamington Road to purchase a Wi-Fi router, only to encounter a Chromecast-like screen-casting device at an extremely affordable price which I just can’t help but buy. Or entering a large-format retail store to purchase a laptop for a friend and getting enamoured by power banks sold at competitive prices. These trivial

purchases of things that I didn’t plan on buying are executed better while shopping offline compared to shopping online, where what you see is based on your search and buying history, thereby restricting the scope of discovering new products. And I like this aspect of my offline shopping experience.

Shopping in a physical store also means maintaining bonds that have spanned years. The number has reduced and opportunities for face-to-face meetings have dwindled, mostly owing to time constraints, but I still have a few trustworthy sellers and shop owners in Mumbai that I like to frequent as often as I can – folks who have sold me everything from acid-washed jeans to PC peripherals, consumer appliances to electrical and electronic equipment.

Shopping offline also gives me the option to get off my arse and indulge in more than just isolated purchases. For e.g., my wife and I can go to a mall together, where she’s busy checking out clothes, while I’m playing with gadgets. Call some friends over and engage in some RnR, too, if possible. As an activity, buying is more fun here, than just random clicking and tapping buttons on a website. Shopping offline is so much more than just saving a thousand rupees here or there. This is where shopping online seems so impersonal, cold and business-like, and even uninviting at times.

I’m all for buying online. For those who don’t have local options, these e-portals are saviours! But for folks who have never truly experienced the joys (and pains) of buying offline, don’t wash your hands off it just yet. Give it a try and even if you don’t end up buying anything in a physical store, at least it would count as an additional step of research which propels you to ultimately buy online, ridding yourself of all doubt. What can be a better reward than that? Win-win-win! 

Got feedback about this column?
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